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Mormonism in *A Study in Scarlet*: Colonization on the Frontiers (of Sherlockian Logic)

A Study in Scarlet recounts Jefferson Hope's murder of Enoch Drebber and Joseph Stangerson. Although it occurs in London, the homicide is precipitated by events in Utah Territory, which introduced a British audience to a vast frontier both untamed and beautiful. The land, which functions in the text as the quintessence of American alterity, is inextricably related to John Ferrier, Jefferson Hope, and Lucy Ferrier, Arthur Conan Doyle's independent and beautiful young woman whose capture by Brigham Young's band mirrors the settlement and colonization of the landscape. In this essay, I argue that Conan Doyle's exotic depiction of the land and its inhabitants complicates the precarious relationship between the Mormon adherents and Conan Doyle's idealized American West. Like seventeenth- and eighteenth-century settlers, Brigham Young and his devotees strike off on their own with the stated goal of religious freedom, but in doing so they impose a colonial order on what Conan Doyle describes as an uncultivated environment. Furthermore, this particular representation of colonization and the American West occupies an anomalous place in the Holmes canon. What has become known as the "Mormon segment" in Conan Doyle criticism is never actually reported to Holmes or Watson in *A Study in Scarlet*; they solve the case with none of the backstory that was provided to the reader. I argue that the seemingly disparate Mormon episode functions as a formal frontier of Sherlock Holmes's system of logical deduction. The exoticized Utah desert and project of colonization circumvents Holmes's usual methods of analysis, which attests to the complexities of colonialism and displacement in the nineteenth-century American West.

A Critical History of *A Study in Scarlet*

Any analysis of Conan Doyle's first Holmes novel must consider two issues that have preoccupied critical responses to *A Study in Scarlet* since it first appeared in *Beeton's Christmas Annual* in 1887: Conan Doyle's portrayal of Mormonism and the American West and *Study*'s so-called "divided" narrative. In telling one story, *A Study in Scarlet* relates two narratives, one detailing the celebrated meeting of Holmes and Watson and the resolution of their first case together and the other a suspenseful and expeditious recounting of religious despotism, murder, and polygamy in the deserts of Utah. The two sections operate almost autonomously as evidenced by the

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shift in narrative styles, the combination of genres, and the transition from Victorian London to the American West.

Unlike most contemporary critics, many of *A Study in Scarlet*'s early reviewers praised the novel's unorthodox construction. "The tale is thoughtfully worked out," muses a reviewer from the *Portsmouth Chat* (qtd. in Pollack and Lellenberg 2). Similarly, *The Graphic*'s review lauds the "daringly constructed" plot wherein "the crime is cleared in the middle of the volume, [with] the remainder being given to its preliminary history" and remarks that "this unconventional departure is justified by success, and by the complete renewal and maintenance of fresh interest to the close" (4). *The Hampshire Post* also marks the excitement of the "Mormon segment" but criticizes Conan Doyle's "inartistic introduction" of the novel's second half (4). This reference to the novel's "clumsy" structure predicts the common reaction of many twentieth-century Holmesian critics to *A Study in Scarlet*'s "divided" narrative.[1]

Contemporary responses to the structure of *A Study in Scarlet* essentially fall into three categories: unfavorable, defensive, and explanatory. I shall first outline the unfavorable reaction because it has been the dominant one. In his psychoanalytic reading of the rift in the narrative, Michael Atkinson acknowledges that many readers have found fault with "the oft-remarked and occasionally lamented seam between the first and second halves of the novel":

> Part I is established as a reprint from Watson's reminiscences, and conforms to the conventions it establishes by having Watson narrate the sequence of events of the London crime, from the moment it first comes to his and Holmes's attention through the arrest of the perpetrator. But Part II, on the other hand, begins with an account of the events in America which resulted in the crimes the pair was engaged in solving. (69)

Part II ends with a conscious "return" to Watson's narrative, signifying that the "Mormon segment" was not penned by Watson, Holmes's longtime Boswell.

Negative reactions range from designating the Mormon segment as confusing (Vizoskie 29), disorienting (McLaughlin 118), or unpopular (Bragg 12), and some readers, even the most avid of Sherlockians (such as Lenore Carroll and Loren Estleman), simply skip the Utah adventure.[2] In fact, the Mormon segment seems to have been eliminated entirely from some early reissues of *Study*.[3] Many Holmes critics dispute the historical and geographical accuracy of "The Country of the Saints." Some view "Saints" as a mixture of historical fact and fiction while others vehemently deny the historicity of the Mormon segment and implicate Conan Doyle in continuing the sensationalized myth of Mormonism.[4] Some critics have contextualized *Study*'s structure with that of its genre forebears as well as Conan Doyle's own later works. For example, Colin Loader attributes

Conan Doyle's inspiration for the structure of his novel to the works of Robert Louis Stevenson. But, Loader claims that novels like Stevenson's *The Dynamiters* succeed in achieving a "smooth and unproblematical" continuity while *Study* features a notable disruption in continuity (151). Kelvin I. Jones argues that *Study*'s divided narrative lacks the unity so "clearly apparent to anyone who has enjoyed the tightly constructed plots of *The Adventures* and *The Memoirs*" (52), the first two Holmes short story collections, published in 1892 and 1894, respectively.

My argument is, in part, an explanation of the disorienting quality of *A Study in Scarlet*'s narrative outlined by those in the "negative" response category. Chris Redmond highlights the "two disconnected parts" as a common complaint about *Study* and announces the geographical instability of the text. For Redmond, the divided narrative leaves the reader stranded "in the uncongenial reaches of the American desert" in their search for Holmes (31). Ben Vizoskie refers to *Study*'s geographical discontinuity as traumatic (29) and biographer Jacqueline Jaffe claims that Conan Doyle, during the writing of *Study*, was simply unable to maintain narrative and geographical continuity:

> Doyle did not yet know how to do that, therefore the interest in the detective in this story *is* broken. The two parts of *A Study in Scarlet* are completely different from one another. The American adventure story, set in the arid, sunbaked plains of Utah, is juxtaposed to the English detective story, set in gaslit, foggy London, without any viable transition. By using two such different locations, Doyle had to write two separate stories, a position that left him with a badly split narrative. (36)

Jaffe's unfavorable assessment of the divided narrative presents contrasting descriptions of the English and American landscapes that reflect the different levels of interest she and many others believe readers will invest in each part of the novel. For Jaffe, Conan Doyle's inability to transition smoothly from the shadows of London to the arid American West prevents readers from maintaining interest in the Mormon segment.

A Study in Scarlet's apologists typically argue that the Mormon segment is interesting in its own right, and the "defensive" category of response often includes attempts to explicate a clear connection between the two sections. These critics first identify, as does Christopher Weimer, a need to defend *Study*'s "oft-maligned dual construction" (200). Joseph McLaughlin laments that the first Holmes adventure has remained "obscure, misunderstood, and ignored, largely because of its formal peculiarity" and argues that *Study* deserves to be read, not just because it marks the genesis of one of fiction's bestselling and longest running series but also "more importantly because it is an amalgam of two plots—crime story and Western—which in 1887 had not yet been articulated in genres of their own" (113–14). Carroll claims that the Mormon segment incorporates and invigorates standard

conventions found in popular Westerns since the 1860s. And in response to charges of discontinuity between the detective story and the Western romance, Weimer suggests that "the primary and imbedded narratives are much more deeply related" (202), and Philip Shreffler identifies Jefferson Hope, the erstwhile cowboy turned vigilante, as the unifying feature of *A Study in Scarlet* (137).[5]

Much of the criticism falling into the "explanatory" category of response focuses on so-called "historical" explanations rather than textual explanations. Unless one entirely avoids the critical history of *A Study in Scarlet*, any attempt to enunciate *Study*'s narrative complexities will be somewhat frustrated by those critics who have engaged in "the Great Game," a peculiarity unique to Holmes scholarship. "The Great Game," or what Robert S. Paul calls "the shadowy sphere of Holmesian myth" (46), refers to the attempt by Sherlockians to reconcile inconsistencies found in the Holmes canon by constructing a historical Holmes and Watson. Though their scholarship is mostly facetious, these writers have dedicated much thought and energy to identifying the unnamed and distinct narrator of *Study*'s second half. Poul Arenfalk, Peter Horrocks, L. M. Anderson, Patricia Dodd Flynn, and Vizoskie all deny the possibility of a Watsonian narrator of "The Country of the Saints." All ask "Who wrote these chapters"? and propose various and colorful answers to this question.[6] However, I argue that the important question is not "Where did 'The Country of the Saints' come from"? or even "Why is this section included in *A Study in Scarlet*"? but "Why are Holmes and Watson not privy to the information detailed in the second half of the novel?"

Conan Doyle wrote the last Holmes novel in the same style as the first. But while the "American half" of *The Valley of Fear* is a seamless part of Watson's continuous narration, "The Country of the Saints" differs from Dr. Watson's "Reminiscences" in narrator, tone, setting, style, and characterization. Moreover, the Mormon segment ends and the narrative "returns" to Watson's journal, leaving the reader to question the full extent of Holmes's awareness of the American events. In response, I neither condemn nor defend the divided narrative of *A Study in Scarlet*; rather, my explanatory reading of *Study* accounts for the disruption in continuity via an explication of the relationship between the American characters and Conan Doyle's portrayal of the American West.

The Quintessence of American Alterity: Landscape in "The Country of the Saints"

A confluence of source materials, including sensational literature depicting the lurid practices of the Latter Day Saints, travel brochures promoting sublime and exotic images of the American west, and historical accounts showing pioneer life, were available to Conan Doyle during the writing of *A Study in Scarlet*. Phillip Bergem situates "The Country of the Saints"

as part of a trend of sensationalist portrayals of Mormons (40) that was, according to Michael Homer, a mainstay in the British "yellow press" in the latter decades of the nineteenth century (291). Critics have identified many literary sources as possible inspiration for *A Study in Scarlet* in addition to Stevenson's *The Dynamiter* (1885), including Joaquin Miller's successful play *The Danites, or, The Heart of the Sierras* (1880), Richard Burton's travel narrative "The City of the Saints," and Mark Twain's *Roughing It* (1872). Conan Doyle might also have relied on the "tell all" accounts of ex-Mormons such as Eliza Young, Mary Ettie Smith, John Hyde, John Beadle, William Jarman, and Fanny Stenhouse, all published from 1857 to 1884.[7] Jack Tracy asserts that Conan Doyle's one "proven" source is the autobiography of Stenhouse, an English convert to Mormonism who left the Church after twenty years (15, 17), whose account, according to Lydia Fillingham, "freely mixes moral indignation and hints of titillating secrets" (675–76). Thomas Hafen observes that Mormon stereotypes were almost set by 1860 and that literature with Mormon characters stayed faithful to those images for at least 40 years (349). Indeed, the press promulgated images of Mormons as licentious and greedy, and the reading public devoured novels "graphically describing" the "secret and mysterious customs of the early Mormons" (qtd. in Pollack and Lellenberg 2).

A Study in Scarlet evokes the wide literary myth of the American West. Carroll claims that the Mormon segment "continued and amplified the myths of the American west" (5), and to her argument I would add that "The Country of the Saints" presents and perpetuates the myth of the West as an empty landscape. The opening paragraphs of "Saints" position the desert as a formidable "barrier against the advance of civilization" (1: 55). "Barrier" suggests empty space, and in this case, the empty space is practically impermeable; the narrator reiterates that this space is desolate, silent, barren, and inhospitable. "There are no inhabitants of this land of despair," and even an errant band "of Pawnees or of Blackfeet," who "traverse it in order to reach other hunting-grounds," are not native to the desert (1: 55). The narrator insists that coyotes, buzzards, and grizzly bears are "the sole dwellers in the wilderness" (1: 55), but that above all, silence reigns over the desert: "In this great stretch of country there is no sign of life, nor of anything appertaining to life. . . . Listen as one may, there is no shadow of a sound in all that mighty wilderness; nothing but silence—complete and heart-subduing silence" (1: 56). "Saints" depicts an empty land that, once inscribed into discourse as a *terra nova*, simply awaits settlement and cultivation.

Conan Doyle's Victorian readers must have pictured the American West as empty, if the *Weekly Times & Echo*'s review of *Study* is any indication: "the sketches of the 'Wild West' in its old barren and trackless condition . . . are vivid and well done" (qtd. in Pollack and Lellenberg 3). Contemporary critics also validate the myth in their readings of Conan

Doyle's Western landscape. For both Redmond and McLaughlin, the frontier is made up of "wide-open spaces" (32, 114). "Open" signifies "empty," and McLaughlin reinforces the colonial diction by describing the desert as "dazzlingly empty and clean" (118). The so-called cleanliness of the desert intensifies the depiction of Utah as a "blank space" for the Mormon pioneers. Utah is an empty space wherein the settlers can construct a foundational order on a land portrayed as ahistorical (118). But the landscape is neither "clean" in the sense that it is empty nor is it ahistorical as the colonial verbiage suggests. According to Vizoskie, the Shoshoni, Bannock, Ute, Paiute, and Washoe inhabited Utah or Nevada at this time (30). Conan Doyle's "barrier" that separates colonial America from the "frontier" is merely the land that has not yet been settled by colonists of European extraction. The portrayal of an uninhabited and harsh American West both valorizes the noble exploits of the Mormon colonizers and mitigates colonial guilt over the displacement of native peoples. The representation of an empty land reinforces the idea that the Mormon pioneers made the desert "blossom as the rose" and that they are the sole cultivating presence in the desert.

Conan Doyle's representation of cultivation would likely appeal to a Victorian audience. The illustration of the landscape is exotic to the Victorian reader in the same ways as popular texts written by travelers such as Richard Burton, Isabella Byrd, and Charles Doughty. Portrayed as the colonial *terra nova*, the American West compares to Doughty's Arabia and Burton's southern Africa in capturing the aesthetic ideals of Burke in the Victorian imagination. The "great flat plainland, all dusted over with patches of alkali" is juxtaposed with "snow-capped and lofty mountains," "dark and gloomy valleys," and "swift-flowing rivers which dash through jagged cañons" (1: 55). All elements of the landscape share the same inhospitable and unpredictable nature. The mountains, with a "rugged surface like the ribs of some petrified monster" (1: 80–81) endanger the protagonists' flight from their polygamous pursuers. A "wild chaos of boulders" hinders the group's progress, and success is only possible because all three are experienced riders (1: 81). But despite all the dangers, Hope and the Ferriers witness scenes of "marvellous though savage beauty" in the mountains (1: 82). Thomas Hafen observes that it was just this sort of exotic and unpredictable image that travel guides promoting Western tourism invoked in order to entice eastern and European visitors (342).

The protagonists of "The Country of the Saints"—John Ferrier, Lucy Ferrier, and Jefferson Hope—share an inextricable and nuanced connection to the land. The initially empty desert has concealed John Ferrier, and the reader's first impression of the solitary traveler is that he might be either "the very genius or demon of the region" (1: 56). This paradoxical description refers to Ferrier's appearance; though his face is considerably weathered, his exceptionally large build signifies his "wiry and vigorous

constitution" (1: 56). Ferrier has managed to endure the hopelessness and hostility of the "Great Alkali Plain," and when Brigham Young's caravan stops to investigate Ferrier's presence in the desert, he explains that he and Lucy are "all that's left o' twenty-one people," the rest being "dead o' thirst and hunger away down in the south" (1: 62). The opening scene of "Saints" marks Ferrier as the American West's natural inhabitant.

Ferrier accepts the condition of his and Lucy's rescue by Young—that they convert to Mormonism—and the pioneers recognize his skills as especially suitable to Western life. Ferrier distinguishes himself as "a useful guide and an indefatigable hunter" and proves to be so indispensable to the group that he is accorded honors reserved for those members highest in the Mormon hierarchy: "as large and as fertile a tract of land as any of the settlers, with the exception of Young himself, and of Stangerson, Kemball, Johnston, and Drebber, who were the four principal Elders" (1: 64). Thanks to his resourcefulness, Ferrier thrives in the Salt Lake Valley: he builds a "substantial log-house" that becomes a "roomy villa"; his practicality, dexterity, and "iron constitution" enable him "to work morning and evening at improving and tilling his lands"; his farm prospers and Ferrier grows exceedingly rich; and his success garners Ferrier wide-reaching esteem (1: 64–65). Ferrier takes so naturally to the Great Basin that his success outstrips that of almost anyone in Salt Lake City.

But Ferrier's prosperity becomes untenable once the Mormon leaders institute an invisible network of surveillance throughout the land. Brigham Young presses Ferrier to marry Lucy to either Drebber or Stangerson when he hears of her engagement to Hope, a non-Mormon. Young gives Ferrier a month to decide. An unseen force daily infiltrates his home to scrawl the number of the remaining days on a surface that Ferrier is sure to see, and these markings remind him of the impending peril that will befall him should he disobey the command of the Prophet. Ferrier contemplates escape, but his skill as a guide and hunter falters under the control of the colonizers: "Single-handed, and with his limited knowledge of the mountains which surrounded the settlement, he knew that he was powerless" (1: 77). As the Mormons exert increasing control over the land and its resources, Ferrier's indigenous connection to the land diminishes and he is unable to challenge the newly settled Mormon hierarchy.

Critical discussions of Lucy Ferrier and Jefferson Hope dismiss the characters as stereotypes, though Hope fares somewhat better because he presents an intriguing foil for Holmes. Lucy is defined by McLaughlin as a "stereotypical heroine of Romance" (121) and by Tanya Agathocleous as "the virtuous, wronged maiden" (129), and she is, along with Irene Adler, notably absent from Sheila Sullivan's examination of American women characters in the Holmes stories. I do not dispute Lucy's status as stock character; rather, I argue that Lucy emblematizes Conan Doyle's idea of quintessential American beauty.

Lucy is "as fair a specimen of American girlhood as could be found in the whole Pacific slope," and like John Ferrier, is closely identified with the land (1: 65). Conan Doyle compares Lucy's development to the growth of a flower. The careful tending by "the keen air of the mountains and the balsamic odour of the pine trees" that "took the place of nurse and mother" provides a space for Lucy to blossom (1: 65). Like a flower, Lucy blossoms in the same environment that enriches John Ferrier, and like the American West, she is unpredictable and untamed. The language of the scene in which Lucy rushes headlong into "a great drove of cattle, driven by a half-dozen wild-looking herdsmen from the plains" (1: 66) invokes the description of Hatty Doran, an American girl in a later Holmes story, "The Noble Bachelor": "with a strong nature, wild and free. . . . She is impetuous—volcanic . . . She is swift in making up her mind and fearless in carrying out her resolutions" (1: 395). Hatty, like Lucy, is uncultivated—hence her appeal to the British aristocrat who intends to transform her from a California coal miner's daughter into a British peeress. Lucy's capture by Brigham Young's band mirrors British settlement and colonization of exotic lands, and her body serves as the landscape on which that reenactment occurs.

For some critics, Jefferson Hope is the quintessential American cowboy, complete with a reputation as a loner. Shreffler characterizes Hope as "the very image of the American frontier from which he sprang," with the qualification that this image may have only existed "in the imagination of the eastern United States and of Europe in the late nineteenth century" (137). Indeed, Hope is as natural an inhabitant of Conan Doyle's American West as John Ferrier and Lucy. In fact, Conan Doyle's description of Hope as "a tall, savage-looking young fellow, mounted on a powerful roan horse, and clad in the rough dress of a hunter, with a long rifle slung over his shoulders" (1: 67) clearly invites a comparison with the American Indian of Western myth. Like Lucy, Hope is volcanic, untamed, passionate, and resolute (1: 68). And as if mirroring the image of John Ferrier as the genius or demon of the desert, the specter of Jefferson Hope haunts the mountains for months after Lucy's death (1: 87). Though Conan Doyle identifies Hope with the land in much the same way as the Ferriers, critics regularly classify Hope as "outsider." Referring to Hope as an outsider, however, reiterates the Mormon governance structure's colonial dynamic.

Hope's inventory of Western exploits further authenticates his claim on the land. He capitalizes on his adventurer's ethos in his courting of Lucy, and in a scene reminiscent of Othello recounting his trials to Desdemona and her father, Hope entertains the Ferriers with stories of his days as a pioneer in California, a scout, a trapper, a silver prospector, and a ranchman (1: 68). Hope refers to himself as "a Washoe hunter" (1: 78), and the narrator, especially during the protagonists' attempted escape from Utah and in Hope's later pursuit of Drebber and Stangerson, repeatedly refers to Hope as a hunter. The calculated method by which Hope hunts and kills

the Salt Lake City exiles reflects the "indomitable patience and perseverance" and "power of sustained vindictiveness" that he "may have learned from the Indians amongst whom he had lived" (1: 85).[8] But despite Hope's "intimate knowledge of the mountains" (1: 81), Brigham Young's invisible system closes in on the protagonists. In fact, Hope, the Washoe-trained hunter and tracker, becomes uncharacteristically disoriented in the mountains when trying to return to the Ferriers' camp with food (1: 83–84). His delay provides Drebber and Stangerson with the time needed to catch John and Lucy. Because Hope can access all natural spaces, critics who label Hope an "outsider" read him as operating outside of the Mormon governing structure, inherently challenging their foundational relationship to the landscape by representing an Other—in this case, with equal or greater knowledge of the land.

In the end, the Mormons' act of colonizing and controlling the land destroys the protagonists. Drebber and Stangerson easily overtake the Ferriers when they are alone in the mountains, and Stangerson murders the hardy John. Lucy wilts and dies after being kidnapped and forcibly married to Drebber. And the turn of events transforms the passionate Jefferson Hope into a cold, calculated vigilante. But I dispute the charge that "The Country of the Saints" merely catalogues negative stereotypes of the early Mormons. Rather, Conan Doyle's representation of Mormons in the American frontier illuminates tension between his appreciation for their pioneer spirit and his antipathy toward their religious practices, and details the complexities of identity and displacement in the nineteenth-century American West.

Conan Doyle's depiction of America as an exoticized Other is complicated by the precarious relationship between the Mormon adherents and Conan Doyle's idealized America. Like the seventeenth-century settlers, Brigham Young and his devotees strike off on their own to pursue religious freedom, and in so doing, the Mormons reenact the initial conquest of the Americas in Utah territory. Conan Doyle's Victorian readers may have been captivated by the foreignness of Utah and the Mormon characters, but they also might have appreciated Brigham Young's pioneer spirit and identified with his colonial endeavors. Naturally, Brigham Young's appearance—a massive head and resolute expression—immediately signifies to Ferrier that Young is the leader of the caravan (1: 63). Brigham Young leads his caravan to Salt Lake Valley in a highly organized manner, and on arriving, proves to be a "skillful administrator" and "resolute chief" (1: 64). Young expedites the planning and construction of Salt Lake City, apportions farms to each family, and oversees the growth and prosperity of the whole settlement that "sprang up, as if by magic" (1: 64). Young appears to have as much ease cultivating the land as John Ferrier, though the inclusion of the word "magic" lends an otherworldly—unnatural—quality to his colonial administration.

The narrator breaks in to comment that the story of the Ferriers' journey to Utah "is not the place to commemorate the trials and privations endured by the immigrant Mormons before they came to their final haven." However, he briefly does just that:

> From the shores of the Mississippi to the western slopes of the Rocky Mountains they had struggled on with a constancy almost unparalleled in history. The savage man, and the savage beast, hunger, thirst, fatigue, and disease—every impediment which Nature could place in the way—had all been overcome with Anglo-Saxon tenacity. . . . There was not one who did not sink upon his knees in heartfelt prayer when they saw the broad valley of Utah bathed in the sunlight beneath them, and learned from the lips of their leader that this was the promised land, and that these virgin acres were to be theirs for evermore. (1: 63–64)

In his commemorative account of the Mormons' struggles, Conan Doyle combines two of his most frequently emphasized myths: that the frontier was empty on the arrival of the Mormons—"virgin acres"—and that the British share with the Mormon pioneers particular character traits—"Anglo-Saxon tenacity" (1: 63–64). Presumably, without this quality, the settlement of the West would have been entirely fruitless.

But despite shared values, "The Country of the Saints" presents Mormonism and Utah as far removed from the landscape of Holmes's Victorian London. Fillingham claims that for the Victorians, "polygamy represented the furthest reaches of taboo exoticism," and that Mormonism "seemed bizarre and perhaps heathen" (674). Conan Doyle portrays organized Mormonism as autocratic, especially as it concerns the enforcement of religious doctrines such as polygamy, and the men as unforgivably lecherous. The introduction of the "Danite Band, or the Avenging Angels" initiates the reader into the secret, sinful world of early Mormonism, or at least the mythic idea of it. Conan Doyle's Danite Band holds innumerable responsibilities to the Saints' governing body, including visiting "swift retribution" on those who dared to "express an unorthodox opinion," which was, according to a momentary retrospective on the part of the narrator, "a dangerous matter in those days in the Land of the Saints" (1: 70). Men who disagree with the Church vanish, and strange women suddenly appear to repopulate the "harems of the Elders" (1: 70). Conan Doyle compares the Avenging Angels to the Inquisitors—in order to emphasize their sinister methods of persecution, according to Carroll (1)—and cloaks the group in invisibility to make the organization "doubly terrible" in the minds of the brethren (1: 70).

Organized Mormonism, especially during the reign of the Danite Band, is never portrayed as a natural part of the landscape. Rather, it is a toxin that infiltrates the space unseen and slowly poisons the land; the activities of the Avenging Angels "cast a cloud over the state of Utah" (1: 70). And

for the fugitives John, Lucy, and Jefferson, the land "looked so peaceful and happy, the rustling trees and the broad silent stretch of grainland, that it was difficult to realize that the spirit of murder lurked through it all" (1: 79). Brigham Young warned John Ferrier against acting as "that little speck of decay which in time corrupts the whole fruit" (1: 63); but though Ferrier fulfills Young's prophecy and turns apostate, it is the Danite Band that in colonizing the landscape, poisons the landscape. In its portrayal of Mormons and the American West, "The Country of the Saints" complicates the image of "quintessential" America.

A Study in Scarlet's Latter Day Saints manage to subdue the hostile desert, but their hold over the land evinces a tension that is not present in the protagonists' relationship with the land. Conan Doyle portrays the Mormon community as grafted on to the landscape, and in so doing, makes "outsiders" of Brigham Young and his band. Weimer, among others, refers to John Ferrier and Jefferson Hope as outsiders—specifically, outsiders to the system of organized Mormonism (203), and Sullivan further emphasizes Hope's outsider status in calling the character "a secret society of one" (101). Hope clearly cannot act within the Saints' justice system; as Anderson points out, the Ferriers' murderers are "part of the ruling elite of the community, and cannot be brought to legal justice" (137). Though Hope tries to avenge the deaths of the Ferriers in Utah, he's "foiled by chance and the wealth and power of his enemies" (142), advantages they have gained as part of the Mormon hierarchy. But though Hope is "outsider" to organized Mormonism, he has, like John and Lucy, an intimate knowledge of and operates within *A Study in Scarlet*'s dominant system: the landscape.

Because contemporary readers can dispel the myth of the American West as *terra nova*, the Mormons' implantation there reads as more of a colonial imposition than a settlement on a vast, unpopulated landscape. Conan Doyle's Victorian readers would have been appalled—but probably also intrigued—by the Saints' use of tyranny, murder, and polygamy to institute control over the landscape. Though the pioneers managed to adapt to and even thrive in the land, they impose an imperial order that subordinates natives to the land as well as the landscape itself. The Danite Band learns the terrain enough to terrorize the Ferriers and Hope, and Hope is momentarily thwarted by the colonizers; but though Hope's skill at hunting and tracking, and even reading a crime scene, allows him to succeed in the end, it is clear that the Danites' drive for colonial order has led to the consolidation of power over individuals and the landscape.

By setting *A Study in Scarlet* in the Americas, Conan Doyle invokes both familiarity and foreignness in his first Holmes tale and demonstrates a colonial kinship between America and England. In fact, Holmes exhibits a stalwart faith in globalization throughout the series, and in "The Noble Bachelor," the detective expresses the desire to see the unification of Britain and its former colony to create "the same world-wide country under a flag

which shall be a quartering of the Union Jack with the Stars and Stripes" (1: 406). *Study*'s Mormon pioneers, in their expansion westward, reenact the British colonial efforts that, according to Stephen Arata, Conan Doyle privately defended (141). Arata claims that *A Study in Scarlet* begins the Holmes canon "under the shadow of empire" and that the series remains preoccupied with matters of empire (139, 141). Many of Holmes's adventures reach India, Afghanistan, South Africa, and Australia without leaving England. But these colonial influences prove to be more familiar within the world of the series because these colonies are more integrated with cosmopolitan Britain than the American West.

Circumventing the "Good Old Index": Holmes on the Borders of the Frontier

Critics categorize Holmes's sphere of activity in one of two ways, claiming either that he enforces Victorian jurisprudence or that he operates wholly outside of the legal code.[9] The series provides ample evidence in support of both claims, but while Holmes alternatively upholds and circumvents the law, his association with Victorian legalism cannot be reduced to a binary relationship. Watson's observation that "Holmes's smallest actions were all directed towards some definite and practical end" dispels the idea that the detective's behavior is erratic and situates Holmes' activity within his own system of logic (1: 26). Throughout the fifty-six stories and four novels that document his adventures, Holmes serves as the supreme architect of his own overarching system wherein he orders people, places, and events. In making meaning out of and forging connections between disparate events, he restores order to his universe.

During his tenure as a private detective, Holmes periodically claims to represent the official police force. But Holmes has no allegiance to Scotland Yard, and although he usually "upholds the law" as "every other good citizen" would in his place (2: 646), consulting the police before acting engenders fatal consequences. For example, in "The Five Orange Pips," John Openshaw brings his case to Holmes as a last resort after the police dismiss his story of orange seed intrigue. Holmes, irked by the Yarders' characteristic short-sightedness, curses their "incredible imbecility" (1: 297). Openshaw turns up dead—consulting the police before Holmes provided his murderers with time enough to reach him before Holmes could deduce their identities. Bureaucracy clutters the Victorian judicial system, and Holmes often becomes frustrated by the ineptitude of the purveyors of the law. This annoyance is perhaps nowhere more clearly demonstrated than in "The Greek Interpreter." Scotland Yard fails to expedite the search warrant that would have prevented Paul Kratides's murder. Watson notes that "on reaching Scotland Yard, however, it was more than an hour before we could get Inspector Gregson and comply with the legal formalities which would enable us to enter the house" holding Kratides and Melas (1:

608). By the time Holmes and company reach Beckenham, the murderers have gone and Kratides is dead. Holmes breaks in through the window in order for Watson to revive Melas, demonstrating that Holmes works more efficiently without involving the official police force.

Though Holmes occasionally consults the police before acting, he is perfectly comfortable circumventing Britain's authorities and laws to bring about the solution of a case. Watson is usually complicit in Holmes's misconduct, as in "A Scandal in Bohemia" when Holmes enlists Watson's aid in "breaking the law" and "running a chance of arrest" in retrieving an incriminating photograph from Irene Adler (1: 221). When Mycroft Holmes engages Sherlock in recovering stolen government documents in "The Bruce-Partington Plans," Holmes and Watson bypass a search warrant in favor of breaking into a suspicious house themselves. At the conclusion of "The Solitary Cyclist," Holmes authoritatively instigates a citizen's arrest and orders Watson to hold the criminals at gunpoint. And in perhaps his most flagrant disregard for Victorian jurisprudence, Holmes "tries" the case of the Abbey Grange "in due form of law" himself because he believes in the goodness of the murderer, Captain Crocker. He assigns himself the role of judge and Watson as jury; he and Watson find the "prisoner" not guilty, and never inform the police of their decision (1: 901). Remarkably, the Yarders recognize that they will never force Holmes to submit to their authority; they are, Inspector MacDonald concedes in *The Valley of Fear*, "bound to take [him] on [his] own terms" (2: 205).

The insider/outsider dichotomy assumes that Conan Doyle uses Scotland Yard to represent ultimate order and that Holmes acts either with their sanction or without it. I argue that Holmes, as the focal point of his adventures, operates within a system of his own creation wherein he is the ultimate authority. Not only does he efficiently reconstruct events based on meticulous observation, he renders legal judgment on the reconstituted events by contrasting the event with a juridical logic that he creates and administers. Scotland Yard is merely a means to an end; presenting an offender before the police occupies neither a logical or formal conclusion to Conan Doyle's mysteries. To Holmes, the Yarders are clients just as private citizens are, and there is oftentimes not an actual "crime" to report. For example, in "The Yellow Face," an American woman has concealed her child from a previous interracial marriage from her English husband. Though her deception is revealed, no crime has been committed. This discovery illustrates Holmes's dedication to an orderly resolution of events rather than deliverance to an exterior system of justice.

Holmes's rational and ordered approach to crime requires a network of vast and obscure knowledge. It is Holmes's "business," as he puts it, to both "uphold the law" and "to know what others don't" (1: 341). His vast knowledge serves him in solving cases—especially those cases with foreign influences. For example, in *The Sign of Four*, one of the many cases

with an Indian backstory, Holmes is, as Ronald Thomas points out, "able to hypothesize the identity of the criminal without ever seeing him" (677) because of a vast physical and mental archive that enables Holmes to commit seemingly random events to a system of meaning. One example of this archival phenomenon is Holmes's propensity for recognizing individuals based on tobacco ash; because he mentally records peoples' choice of tobacco, he can identify who might have been at a crime scene because of scattered tobacco ash.

The "index," as Holmes calls it, first appears in "A Scandal in Bohemia." Holmes registers no recognition at the introduction of Irene Adler's name and asks Watson to "kindly look her up in my index" (1: 215). Watson defines Holmes's index as "a system of docketing all paragraphs concerning men and things, so that it was difficult to name a subject or a person on which he could not at once furnish information" (1: 215). The index comprises a multiplicity of books containing an alphabetical list of any person, place, thing, event, etc. that Holmes might find useful. The index provides Holmes and Watson with information on Colonel Moran, Moriarty's most important employee, in "The Empty House" as well as a record of vampires in "The Sussex Vampire." And, the index helps Holmes tie murders and other misdeeds that occur in London to their colonial origins. For example, in pursuing John Openshaw's case, Holmes uses the index to research the Ku Klux Klan and to draw the conclusion that former members had been terrorizing the Openshaw men with envelopes containing orange seeds that forecast the receiver's death.

Holmes clearly values order and connectivity. In fact, *A Study and Scarlet* is named for Holmes's belief that everything within his system is connected: "There's the scarlet thread of murder running through the colourless skein of life, and our duty is to unravel it, and isolate it, and expose every inch of it" (1: 33). Holmes uncovers connections running throughout his system that are unnoticed by everyone else. The metaphor of connectivity shifts when Watson anchors Holmes and connectivity to London. Instead of a thread connecting all things, it is Holmes himself, who prefers the city to the country, and "love[s] to lie in the very centre of five millions of people, with his filaments stretching out and running through them, responsive to every little rumour or suspicion of unsolved crime" (2: 321). Wilson Hoffman suggests that Holmes is more at home in the city because "despite teeming crowds and mazes of streets, crime might be detected and law and order maintained better in cities than in the countryside" (86). Holmes's experience validates this claim, and in "The Copper Beaches," he remarks to Watson that "the lowest and vilest alleys in London do not present a more dreadful record of sin than does the smiling and beautiful countryside" because crimes can be better hidden in the lonely country, far from either the police or public scrutiny (1: 438–39). Like Utah, the English countryside is almost beyond the reach of order;

consequently, Holmes prefers London. He marks a "wonderful chain of events" winding through "this great city" (1: 251), and appreciates London for that reason.

London constitutes part of Holmes's vast catalogue of knowledge, and Watson observes time and again that Holmes has networked London's streets. Holmes's knowledge "of the byways of London was extraordinary" (1: 672) and he puts his knowledge to use in *The Sign of Four*. Sholto's man picks up Holmes, Watson, and Mary Morstan in a cab and keeps their destination and route secret. Watson tries to discover their direction, but quickly becomes disoriented. Holmes, however, rattles off street names as the cab lurches through London. Because it functions as the epicenter of his system, Holmes has catalogued anything that could come in contact with cosmopolitan London.

Critics regularly describe Holmes as a defender of the commonwealth from colonial influence. McLaughlin, who locates Holmes "on the fringes of the official police force," argues that he protects "the national center from corrosively dangerous foreign influence" from his socially marginalized position (116). Susan Cannon Harris claims that Holmes puts his vast knowledge to use in "allay[ing] anxieties about the potentially harmful effects on metropolitan culture of England's increasingly intimate contact with the peoples and cultures on the peripheries of the Empire" (448). In Conan Doyle's stories, contact with the colonies is usually indirect and comes through English men and women who have lived abroad, return to England, and, as Thomas observes, "almost always have been unduly influenced by the exotic" (661–62). Oftentimes, his criminals are foreign nationals. I acknowledge that the criminal activity of most of Holmes's adversaries takes root in the colonies, but I argue that Holmes's aim is not necessarily to protect England from foreign influence; rather, he orders and catalogues these influences.

If Holmes is inextricably linked with London and London is the heart of the empire, then it follows that Holmes's catalogue of imperial knowledge would extend to even the farthest corners of England's sphere of colonial influence. Because my conclusion hinges in part on a direct refutation of this claim as elucidated by Agathocleous, I shall first outline her thesis. Agathocleous argues that in *A Study in Scarlet*, Holmes demonstrates the connection between the murder of Drebber and Stangerson in London and political and religious oppression in Utah. Holmes views London as part of a "web in which the city is only one intricate component of a global totality" (125). In imagining a global community, Doyle presents "the city as a borderless space that spills exuberantly out onto the world," and Holmes exercises "control over an increasingly unknowable city and world" through his ability to deduce a connection between London and Utah (126, 135). Sullivan reiterates this claim, arguing that *Study*'s two parts "reveals the extent to which Holmes's private business is entwined with the larger

idea of a national response to a criminality which ignores geographical boundaries" (101).

Indeed, Holmes values order and connectivity and views London as part of a far-reaching network; however, I dispute the claim that Conan Doyle presents a world without borders. *A Study in Scarlet*'s structure institutes a boundary, and occupies an anomalous place in the Holmes canon in that it introduces a landscape that exists on the frontier of Holmes's system of logical deduction. *A Study in Scarlet*'s disjointed structure prevents Holmes and Watson from internalizing the narrative context of the murder detailed in "The Country of the Saints." Part I of Watson's "Reminiscences" ends with the capture of Hope, who agrees to answer any questions asked by Holmes and Inspectors Gregson and Lestrade. Part II opens with a description of the hostile conditions of the Western desert. Hope is referred to in the third person throughout the Mormon segment, so we can be reasonably assured that he is not narrating this sequence. And it only becomes clear that Watson did not narrate "Saints" when Chapter 6 closes the narration of the Utah events before returning to the primary account: "As to what occurred [in London], we cannot do better than quote the old hunter's own account, as duly recorded in Dr. Watson's Journal, to which we are already under such obligations" (1: 89). The concluding chapters of *Study* open with Holmes and Watson having no knowledge of the Utah events.

Hope recounts the London murders but provides no clear motive. "It don't much matter to you why I hated these men," he tells the assembled, and offers only "it's enough that they were guilty of the death of two human beings—a father and daughter" (1: 91). Hope tells a "remarkable statement" that leaves out any mention of Mormonism, Utah, polygamy, and only mentions John and Lucy's names in passing. Hope simply references Salt Lake City and "shameless harems" without connecting these snippets to the larger political context of the previous chapters. But neither Holmes nor Watson ever acknowledges that a connection to the Utah backstory has been clearly elucidated. Holmes makes it as far as Cleveland; he telegraphs the Cleveland police for further information on Drebber, and the message returns only that Drebber "applied for the protection of the law against an old rival in love, named Jefferson Hope" (1: 102). This information satisfies Holmes in his deduction that the murder of Drebber "must have been a private wrong, and not a political one" (1: 101). The woman's ring found on Drebber's body suggests a romantically-motivated murder, and the telegram confirms it. Holmes follows the "chain of logical sequences" no further (1: 102).

If Holmes can, in *The Sign of Four*, connect theft and murder in London to the Andaman Islands, identify similar connections to India in "The Speckled Band," and read imperial politics in a box of severed ears in "The Cardboard Box," why does he fail to trace and clarify the connection between *Study*'s London murder and the Utah events? It is not

an American problem specifically because Holmes's method of deduction in other American stories, including "The Five Orange Pips," "The Noble Bachelor," and "The Dancing Men," proves sound. The connection between events in *Study* remains unintelligible. Holmes's commitment to global interconnectedness allows him to trace colonial influences back to their origins, and typically he deduces much more about global identity from clues—like an especially small water dish in "The Speckled Band"—than he does in *Study*. But he cannot trace Drebber's and Stangerson's murders back to their origins in the American West because the American frontier, unlike colonized spaces as far away as Africa and South Asia, isn't yet globalized. Holmes's "encyclopedic knowledge of the globe" is exemplified in countless stories, and yet he displays no knowledge or awareness of Mormons or Utah, or the American West generally. It does not appear that, either literally or figuratively, the American West arises in Holmes's catalogue as we would assume it might, given how Holmes's system of knowledge includes information relating to the colonies. The Mormon section seems disjointed not because it is irrelevant to the narrative of *A Study in Scarlet*, but because it is outside Holmes's London-centric system of logic that is based on meticulous observations of events in the cosmopolitan empire.

Shreffler and Loader both align Hope and Holmes as outsiders to their respective systems and argue that they act as anti-official representatives of justice. However, I have shown that these perspectives misidentify the systems that the two characters are alleged to act outside of. For Hope, the dominant system is not organized Mormonism but the landscape of the American West. And Holmes acts within the bounds of an orderly system of connections that he has created wherein he catalogues knowledge even tangentially related to the nineteenth-century British Empire. Mormonism and the American West lie outside Holmes's purview. Not only does the map of Utah appear devoid of the many lines and markings of Victorian London, but it also does not exist within Holmes's catalogue. The formal and narrative disjointedness of *A Study in Scarlet*, combined with the fact that Holmes himself has no archived information on the Utah desert or the Mormons, suggests that the American frontier likewise functions as a frontier of Holmes's system of logic.

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Notes

[1] In "Becoming a 'Mere Appendix': The Rehabilitated Masculinity of Sherlock Holmes," Tom Bragg acknowledges that the introduction of the second half is "clumsily executed," but claims that the Mormon segment serves an important purpose (12). According to Kelvin Jones in "The Significance of a Study in Scarlet," Conan Doyle achieves narrative cohesion in *The Valley of Fear* "to much greater and more skillful effect" (53).

[2] Ben Vizoskie, Joseph McLaughlin, Lenore Carroll, and Bragg each represent these various negative responses as practically universal.
[3] See Donald Redmond.
[4] On charges of historical inaccuracy in *A Study in Scarlet*, see Jack Tracy, Michael Homer, Jean Beckner, Phillip Bergem, Patricia Dodd Flynn, and Vizoskie.
[5] Shreffler sees Hope as unifying the two parts: "During the first half of the novel (the main Watsonian narrative), Hope lurks just behind or beyond the action, like Moby-Dick or Count Dracula pervading the plot but never making an appearance. All we learn of him is at second hand. . . . We know Hope is out there, we know it from the third chapter of the book. His is a paradoxically solid yet vaporous presence—presence in the sense of the word that a psychic medium might employ. Within the framework of the novel, Hope is something like the Fates, weaving the destinies of others, manipulating stage properties, pulling strings. It is only through the applied logic of Sherlock Holmes that this supernatural quality is undermined, Hope as Fate ultimately chagrined at having been discovered at his work" (140).
[6] Arenfalk looks to the end of the Mormon segment and points out that Watson would be unlikely to refer to his own account in the third person: "Who can have written this story? Not Watson, for the tale ends with these words: 'As to what occurred there, we can do no better than quote….' So there is good reason for cutting this story out of the book and seeing what facts we can extract from Parts I and III, Watson's report" (128); Anderson highlights the shift in narrative voice: "The accuracy of this account is, therefore, open to question, with regard to Hope's feelings. Even if Hope left a written version of the story, it is unlikely that he would have written it, as we now have it, in the third person" (142); Vizoskie claims that, since "Watson's narrative makes it clear that Watson never spoke to Hope about Hope's life in America," Hope must have told his story "to his friend, the man who helped Hope retrieve Lucy's wedding ring from Holmes. It was that person who was responsible for these small errors in the narrative (29, 33); and Flynn suggests that "Hope left a manuscript explaining the history of his vendetta against Drebber and Stangerson" (10).
[7] For additional historical sources, see Bergem 40, Beckner 257, Homer 101, and Carroll 4.
[8] The narrator's characterization of Hope's "native" traits troubles Flynn, who claims that, "despite the narrator's attempt to attribute Hope's ruthlessness and vindictiveness to his years with the Washoe tribe, the Washoe were, in fact, a peace-loving and harmonious people who had suffered greatly at the hands of the neighboring Paiutes" (12–13).
[9] For critical readings of Holmes as "outsider," see Christopher Clausen; Sullivan, Andrew Smith, Loader, McLaughlin, and Shreffler.

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